

Reflexive Qualitative Research and Generative AI: A Call to go Beyond the Binary

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Abstract

Recent debates on generative artificial intelligence (AI) in qualitative research have been framed in increasingly polarized terms, positioning researchers as uncritical adopters or principled refusers. Drawing on recent position statements and editorial guidance, this article argues that such binary framing is unhelpful. While endorsing core concerns about meaning-making, reflexivity, bias, and environmental harm, it suggests that these concerns do not justify categorical rejection of all AI use. Instead, the article proposes refocusing debate on epistemic authority, distinguishing AI-led analysis from human-led practices, and developing governance-oriented responses to ethical and environmental risks. Moving beyond moral binaries is essential to preserving reflexive qualitative inquiry.

Keywords

reflexive qualitative research, generative artificial intelligence, epistemic authority, methodological integrity, research governance

I was invited, but declined, to sign the open letter published in this journal from qualitative researchers against the use of generative artificial intelligence (AI) in reflexive qualitative research (Jowsey et al., 2025). I sympathize with many points made in that letter (e.g., that generative AI is incapable of meaning-making, that interpretation of qualitative data is a uniquely human activity, and that AI is energy-hungry and hence environmentally damaging). I greatly respect the scholars who led this initiative and count some of them as my friends and collaborators.

But I am alarmed that the letter contributes—in tone as well as content—to an unhelpful polarization grounded in a simplistic moral binary. At one pole are depicted the modernists and “qualitative positivists,” whose enthusiasm for AI-driven qualitative inquiry is portrayed as embarrassingly superficial, ethically vacuous, and couched in the discourse of techno-optimism and efficiency. At the other pole are the conscientious objectors, whose rejection of AI is absolute, uncompromising, and securely located on the moral high ground. This framing leaves little space for principled disagreement, methodological experimentation, or careful middle positions. Qualitative research deserves a more nuanced response.

As an online response to a preprint of the open letter (Friese, 2025) pointed out, generative AI does not replace

human thinking; at most, it may support or extend it. Just because meaning-making, interpretation, reflexivity, and ethical judgment are irreducibly human activities, it does not follow that all—or even most—uses of AI within qualitative work constitute an abdication of these responsibilities. Qualitative analysis has long involved tools that do not themselves “understand” meaning. Transcription software, qualitative data management systems, search functions, concordance tools, and even coding frameworks are not reflexive agents, yet they are widely accepted so long as researchers retain interpretive authority. The critical question, then, is not whether a tool can make meaning, but whether its use displaces, obscures, or constrains the researcher’s reflexive engagement with data. On this basis, while some forms of AI use may indeed be methodologically incoherent for reflexive qualitative research, others warrant careful scrutiny rather than categorical rejection.

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Concerns about the environmental and social costs of generative AI are both legitimate and urgent, but here too a binary response risks foreclosing more productive forms of governance. The energy demands, water use, labor practices, and extractivist political economies associated with large-scale AI infrastructures demand sustained critical attention. However, refusing to engage with questions of governance—such as scale of use, choice of tools, institutional accountability, or comparative environmental cost—may inadvertently cede these decisions to commercial actors rather than shaping them through scholarly values. A reflexive stance toward AI should therefore include not only principled refusal where warranted but also critical engagement with how harms might be mitigated, regulated, or made visible within research practice.

The increasingly moralized tone of the debate risks hardening divisions within qualitative research communities at precisely the moment when careful, collective reasoning is most needed. A recent editorial in another qualitative journal took an extreme position against AI-supported research, citing the open letter (Levitt, 2026), although it did point out that this position could change as the field develops. Policies and position statements that function primarily as boundary markers of legitimacy may encourage symbolic alignment rather than thoughtful methodological judgment. If qualitative research is to remain reflexive in the fullest sense, it must resist pressures to sort researchers into opposing camps and instead foster sustained discussion about how emerging tools intersect with long-standing epistemic commitments. Moving beyond the binary is not a call for uncritical adoption of generative AI; it is a call to preserve the intellectual seriousness, nuance, and reflexive depth that qualitative research demands.

To that end, I suggest that the qualitative research community—those skeptical of AI and those cautiously open to its use—would benefit from collectively addressing at least four questions. First, where exactly should epistemic authority reside in qualitative research, and how can this be protected regardless of the tools employed? Second, how might we meaningfully distinguish between AI-led analytic practices that displace interpretation and human-led practices in which AI is strictly subordinate? Third, what forms of governance, transparency, and accountability are required to address the environmental, social, and epistemic harms associated with AI use, rather than treating refusal as the only ethical response? Finally, how can qualitative researchers debate these issues without reproducing moral binaries that undermine the reflexive, dialogic ethos on which the field depends?

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Author Biography

Trisha Greenhalgh is dual qualified in medicine and the social sciences. At the University of Oxford, UK, she leads a programme of research at the interface between social sciences and healthcare. She has a particular interest in qualitative methodology.